

Authentic Self: Authenticity, Play, and Exploration

with Dr. Scott Lyons



AGENDA

Movement Discovery and Sensory
Odyssey Practice
Authenticity
The Science of Play
Trauma and Oxytocin
Q & A
Breakout Sessions

Authenticity

- Trauma Undermines the Self- disrupts presence, openness, and self-connection
- *We often sacrifice authenticity for attachment*, surrendering authentic impulses
 - Infants cannot survive without caregivers and learn to suppress inner needs to maintain connection
 - Over time, this suppression becomes internalized as “inauthentic living”
- Authenticity emerges when safety precedes interoceptive signaling, needs / impulses, choice, expression, and a secure reflection of the expression

Trauma Interrupts:

Impulse → Action → Feedback → Integration

Leads to:

Over-control, Collapse, Social Compliance, Performative Selfhood, Loss of Play Signals

Authenticity

PRACTICES:

- *Somatic Truism* (alignment between sensation and expression)
- *Vocal Expansion* (“freeing the natural voice”)
- *Restore Agency of Expression*
- *Differentiate Somatic Authenticity vs. Performed Authenticity* (become of aware of the “I shoulds”, notice what happens when it’s withheld)
- *Body Mapping*
- *Boundary work*

The Science of Play, Curiosity & Discovery

Curiosity:

The hunger for discovery.

Play:

Freely chosen, self-directed activity that is intrinsically motivated, socially interactive, and involves some degree of physical movement, uncertainty, or risk — without control or predefined outcomes.

- Builds oxytocin-mediated safety
- Trains social flexibility
- Increases error tolerance
- Strengthens sense of agency
- Allows experimentation without consequence

Threat Management → Discovery Mode

Discovery mode is marked by: Dopamine + Oxytocin co-activation

The Science of Play, Curiosity & Discovery

Play is thwarted when:

Mistakes are punished / Expression is shamed / Adults are unpredictable / Attention is fragmented (digital overstimulation)

PRACTICES:

- *Following Pleasure Signals Without Justification*
- *Restore Rhythmic Agency*
- *Low-stakes, Non-Evaluative, Choice-Based*

Trauma and Oxytocin

Oxytocin:

Social Cognition, Social Bonding, Anxiety, Trust, Reward, and Affective Processes, Pain Modulation

Trauma reduces oxytocin receptor sensitivity and release.

Result:

Impaired Bonding, Diminished Trust, Muted Capacity for Pleasurable Social Touch

Oxytocin and Vasopressin

Trauma and Oxytocin

PRACTICES:

- *Focus on Safe, Attuned Relationships / Gradual Exposure to Trust* (receptor sensitivity/upregulating)
- *Safe Touch* (stimulates oxytocin release)
- *Loving-Kindness Meditation and Compassion Practices* (increase levels and sensitivity)
- *Slow Diaphragmatic Breathing, Humming, Vagal Toning, Chanting* (stimulates the vagus nerve modulator)
- *Exercise, Movement, Dance, Synchronized Activity* (stimulates oxytocin release)
- *Repairing Ruptures* (increase levels and sensitivity)



QUESTIONS